Agreement) to show for diplomatic engagement. Pyongyang doubled down on its nuclear and missile program development during Obama's years, conducting nuclear tests in 2009, 2013, and twice in 2016, while launching ballistic missiles on at least a dozen occasions. By the end of Obama's term, Pyongyang was deemed to have a nuclear arsenal of several dozen warheads and had largely perfected intercontinental ballistic missile technology, a capability it demonstrated in the early months of the succeeding Trump administration.

Other elements of Obama's pivot added to complications in relations with Beijing, making an increasingly aggressive Chinese leadership believe that America was seeking to contain China the way it had the Soviet Union. Underscoring the continuing importance of allies, Washington deepened its bilateral security alliance with Tokyo through a revision of the "guidelines" for mutual cooperation. With the return of conservative prime minister Shinzo Abe to office in late 2012, the Obama Asia team found in Japan a willing partner to begin countering Chinese influence in Asia. Japan, with a $50 billion annual defense budget and a highly trained, modernized military, was regarded by Beijing as the Asian nation most capable of opposing Chinese power. Abe moved to dilute or change legal restrictions on Japan's ability to participate in collective self-defense, sell defensive arms equipment abroad, and engage in defense industrial cooperation. Tokyo also increased its commitment to support US forces engaged in military operations in Northeast Asia and continued modernizing its forces, including purchasing up to 140 F-35 stealth fighters, making Japan the largest foreign buyer of the new jet. Abe's cabinet further approved plans to modify its two new helicopter carriers, the largest surface ships in its fleet, to carry new F-35B vertical takeoff and landing jet aircraft. These ships would be the country's first fixed-wing aircraft carriers since World War II, displacing 27,000 tons and giving the Japan Maritime Self-Defense Forces the ability to better protect Japan's far-flung territorial possessions and the potential of working more closely with US naval expeditionary forces throughout the region.[34]